TEPARY BEAN AND SQUASH CHILI

serves 4

Native to the desert lands, tepary beans are drought-tolerant and have a dense, almost meaty texture. Even when soaked, they can take a bit longer to cook than common beans.

Here, I cook them into a chili made with roasted poblanos and dried New Mexico chiles. Squash brings some welcome sweetness and the mesquite flour helps thicken it further. You can serve the chili as is, or top it with Elk Sausage (page 207).

- 1 cup dried tepary beans, soaked overnight and drained
- 1 large onion, halved, and one of the halves chopped
- 4 large garlic cloves, 2 smashed and 2 thinly sliced
- Sea salt
- 1 large poblano chile
- 2 dried New Mexico chiles
- 2 cups vegetable broth
- 3 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 2 cups diced peeled winter squash
- 1 tablespoon mesquite flour
- 1 teaspoon dried Mexican oregano
- ½ teaspoon smoked paprika
- 2 tablespoons cider vinegar
- Elk Sausage with Chiles (optional; page 207), crumbled, for serving
- Finely chopped greens, such as culantro leaves or wild onion or scallion greens

In a large pot, combine the soaked beans, onion half, the 2 smashed garlic cloves, and water to cover by 2 inches. Bring to a boil over high heat. Reduce the heat to medium-low and cook the beans for 1½ to 2 hours, until tender. Add more water as needed to keep them well covered. Remove from the heat, season with salt, and let stand for at least 20 minutes to absorb the seasoning. Reserving 2 cups of the cooking liquid, drain the beans.

Light a gas flame or a grill to medium-high heat or preheat your oven's broiler. Char the poblano directly over the flame or grill under the broiler for 10 to 15 minutes, turning frequently, until blackened all over. Transfer to a bowl, cover with another bowl or plate, and let stand for 10 minutes to steam.

Meanwhile, over the burner or grill, use tongs to hold the dried chiles above the flame and toast them for about 2 minutes turning, until warm and fragrant. (Alternatively, you can toast them in a dry skillet.) Let cool slightly.

Using scissors, snip off the stems of the dried chiles. If you want to reduce the chiles' heat and bitterness, shake out the seeds. Transfer the dried chiles to a small pot and add the broth. Bring to a boil over high heat. Remove from the heat and let stand for about 30 minutes, until the chiles are very soft. Transfer the dried chiles and broth to a blender.

Meanwhile, uncover the poblano and use your hands to pull off and discard the skin. It should slip right off. Remove the stem, open up the poblano, and scrape out the seeds.

Cut the poblano into strips and transfer half of them to the blender. Puree with the dried chiles and liquid until smooth. Set the chile liquid and poblano strips aside.

Wipe out the large pot (used to cook the beans) and warm the sunflower oil over medium heat. Add the chopped onion and the sliced garlic, season with salt, and cook for about 8 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the onion is translucent. Add the diced squash and mesquite flour and stir to coat evenly.

(recipe continues)